

Juliana Pinillos

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USC Dornsife

Dana and David Dornsife
College of Letters, Arts and Sciences
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Education

University of Southern California

Ph.D. in Economics (expected)

May 2027

Paris School of Economics – Université Paris 1 Panthéon-Sorbonne

M.A. in Analysis and Policy in Economics, with High Honors

2020

Universidad del Valle

B.A. in Economics, with High Honors

2016

B.A. in Political Studies and Conflict Resolution

2015

Fields

Urban Economics, Environmental Economics, Development Economics

References

Paulina Oliva

(Co-Chair)

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Andrii Parkhomenko

(Co-Chair)

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Thomas Chaney

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Job Market Paper

Long-Term Effects of Slum Upgrading on Climate Resilience and Urban Growth

This paper studies the long-term effects of slum upgrading on exposure to natural disasters and urban growth. I study PRIMED, a large-scale program implemented in Medellín, Colombia, between 1993 and 2000 that combined neighborhood improvements with risk-mitigation infrastructure. To identify its effects, I exploit the program's incomplete rollout by comparing slums upgraded during phase I with slums from phase II that were scheduled but never treated. I find that upgrading reduces floods and landslides during extreme rainfall events relative to untreated slums, with larger reductions in riskier neighborhoods. The program also increased neighborhood population, primarily through an increase in low-skilled residents. Housing and population density also rose, with higher growth on lower-risk land. I embed these empirical estimates in a quantitative spatial model to measure citywide welfare effects. The results indicate that slum upgrading generates welfare gains for the city, with larger gains among low income residents. Two mechanisms explain this: improved local fundamental amenities and reduced disaster risk exposure. These findings suggest that place-based policies such as slum upgrading can simultaneously promote urban development and climate resilience.

Working Papers

Patchwork Water: Urban Growth, Strained Water Networks, and Household Water Burdens in the Horn of Africa *with Abdiaziz Ali Ahmed, Hernan Bejarano, Jingshu Chen, Kenneth Lee, Alejandro López-Aguilar, and Paulina Oliva*

Publications

Pinillos, Juliana, and Juan Pablo Chauvin. "Spatial Health Inequality in Latin American Cities: Magnitude, Drivers, and Policy Alternatives." In *Inclusive Cities: Healthy Cities for All*, edited by Nora Libertun, 37–59. Inter-American

Development Bank, 2022.

Work in Progress	Rainwater Harvesting in Urban Settings as a Response to Water Shortages (with Paulina Oliva, Alejandro López, and Hernan Bejarano)	
	Spatial Misallocation and Supply–Demand Feedback: Evidence from the Boda-Boda Market in Kampala (with Mychaela Paetow and Santiago Di Martini)	
	Decentralized Water Solutions for Rapidly Growing Cities: Evidence from Hargeisa (with Abdiaziz Ali Ahmed, Hernan Bejarano, Jingshu Chen, Kenneth Lee, Alejandro López-Aguilar, and Paulina Oliva)	
	Cities on Alert: Risk and Urban Development in Brazil (with Bruno Barsanetti and Pedro H. Chaves)	
	Informal Settlements and Natural Disaster Risk: Experimental Evidence from Medellín	
Awards	Department of Economics Dissertation Completion Fellowship, USC	Fall 2026
	Professional Development Fund, USC	2022–2026
	Graduate School Fellowship, USC	2021–2022
	Eiffel Excellence Scholarship, Campus France (€ 24,744)	2018–2020
	Outstanding Paper, International Association of Agricultural Economists	2017
	Santander Bank Scholarship (€ 3,000)	2014
Research Grants	USC Lusk Center for Real Estate Research Award — \$4,835	2026
	USC Economics Summer Research Award — \$2,125	2026
	Innovations for Poverty Action — \$18,717	2025
	J-PAL KCAI — \$123,975 (with Paulina Oliva, Alejandro López, and Hernan Bejarano)	2025
	CEGA — \$8,145 (with Mychaela Paetow and Santiago Di Martini)	2024
	USC Wrigley Institute for Environment and Sustainability — \$6,000	2024
Research Positions	Research Assistant to Paulina Oliva, USC	May 2023–May 2024
	Research Assistant to Juan Pablo Chauvin, Inter-American Development Bank	Sep. 2020–Sep. 2021
	Research Assistant to Ricardo Labarta and Víctor Zuluaga, International Center for Tropical Agriculture	July 2015–Aug. 2018
Teaching	Teaching Assistant, <i>Introduction to Statistics</i> , USC	Spring 2025
	Teaching Assistant, <i>Economic Consulting and Applied Econometrics</i> , USC	Fall 2024
	Teaching Assistant, <i>Health Economics</i> , USC	Spring 2023
	Teaching Assistant, <i>Intermediate Macroeconomics</i> , USC	Fall 2022
	Instructor, <i>Mathematics Applied to Quantitative Social Sciences</i> , Sciences Po	Fall 2020
Presentations	Latin American Urban Economics Network (LAUrban), CAF	12/2026
	Montevideo	
	Urban Economics Association Meeting, Federal Reserve Bank of Chicago	2026
	Economics Seminar, Universidad ICESI, Colombia	2026
	AREUEA International Conference, Universidad EAFIT, Medellín	2026
	International Association of Agricultural Economists Conference, Universidad de Talca	2017

	XII National Microeconomics Symposium, Universidad Externado de Colombia	2016
Academic Events	Invited Attendee, 5th Conference on Spatial Economics, UCLA Anderson	Sept. 11–12, 2026
	RIDGE Summer School and LACEA, Federal University of Pernambuco	2025
	Sloan/Berkeley Summer School in Environmental and Energy Economics, University of California, Berkeley	2023
	Causal Inference Main Workshop, Northwestern University	2023
Service	Committee Member, Women in Economics, USC Department of Economics	2022–2024
Additional	Software: Python, R, JavaScript, Stata, SQL, $\text{\LaTeX}$, QGIS Languages: Spanish (native), English (fluent), French (basic) Citizenship: Colombia	